uniform, beaming from cheek-to-cheek. During this encounter, Honecker and Mielke briefly discussed Brezhnev's increasing senility, which had left him barely able to move. According to former aides, he spoke with difficulty, and his fogginess and confusion could be alarming. On one occasion, convinced that enemy forces were invading Moscow, he refused to retire until reassured that troops were mobilising to stop the imagined attackers. Not long after, he confused a television actor with a Second World War veteran and attempted to have him decorated for bravery.

There was some brief respite from domestic problems in 1980. During a visit to Cuba, Honecker spent time fishing and swimming, and was treated to a monologue from Fidel Castro about a US programme of biological warfare against the island. He accused the US of releasing pests to destroy sugar and tobacco harvests and told Honecker about a series of 'very strange plagues' appearing on the island, which he considered acts of sabotage:

One of these was a fungus on the tobacco plantations, which destroyed 90 per cent of this year's tobacco production and forced us to import tobacco. It involved blue mould. We also had a very serious plague on the sugar plantations. It caused a loss of roughly a million tonnes of sugar. Then we had the African swine fever. We now have this swine fever virtually under control.

Amid all this, the Kremlin was knocked off balance as communist rulers in Poland grappled with widespread shortages, a symptom of massive foreign debt. Stuck in a tricky spot, the Poles implemented a system of gradual but continuous price rises. But as things worsened, a vocal group of Gdansk shipyard workers staged an illegal strike. Led by a charismatic young electrician named Lech Wałęsa, the workers drew up a list of twenty-one demands and refused to leave the docks until they were met. Soon after, they demanded political concessions, resulting in the 'Danzig Agreement', allowing the creation of a self-governing independent trade union with the right to strike.